in 1939. He was nominated over Subhas Chandra Bose. When Bose was nevertheless elected president of the Congress Party for the second consecutive term in 1939, Gandhi bewailed 'Pattabhi's defeat is my defeat'. So Pattabhi Sitaramayya can hardly have been anything other than sympathetic to Gandhism. What Sitaramayya has to say about Gandhi's actions over Bhagat Singh's death sentence is revealing for he explains in his *The History of the Indian National Congress*, 'The Karachi Session was to meet in the last week of March but Gandhi himself definitely stated to the Viceroy that if the boys are to be hanged, they had better be hanged before the Congress, than after.' Definitely stated? Why the desire for such certainty over Bhagat Singh's death? The reason for this, as he makes clear, is that '[t]he position of affairs in the country would be clear. There would be no false hopes lingering in the breasts of the people'. Chillingly, it is then also added that '[t]he Gandhi–Irwin Pact would stand or fall on its own merits at the Congress, and on the added fact that the three boys had been hanged'.[11] Shockingly, the hanging of the three condemned men was to be turned to Congress' advantage. It is in these circumstances that Bhagat Singh ended up being hanged on the night of 23 March 1931.[12] This was not by accident. Although the opening day of the Karachi Congress was on 26th March, the stalwarts of the Congress Party were all to be in Karachi on 24 March. Not only were Gandhi and Bose to take the train across the thousand mile breadth of India from Calcutta to arrive in Karachi on 24 March, but Sardar Vallabhbhai Patel, the newly elected President of the Indian National Congress Party was also to arrive on the same day. Amid the pomp and fanfare of the day, the one distraction that the leadership did not want was to have to deal with Bhagat Singh's hanging. Gandhi would move heaven and earth to prevent this. This is why a telegram was sent on 18 March 1931 by the home secretary of Punjab, H.W. Emerson to the Delhi government, five days before, confirming that the hanging will be brought forward by eleven hours contrary to protocol and take place in Lahore jail at 7pm at night instead (as confirmed in the Appendix herewith).

No wonder that upon his arrival in Karachi, Gandhi was met by several angry young men. The ruse had fooled no one. Ordinarily, the arriving